

News Writing

Invitational A Meet • 2019



You are a reporter for the Leaguetown **Press**, the student newspaper of Leaguetown High School. From the given information, write a **news story** as you would for the high school newspaper. You may use statements attributed to individuals as **direct or indirect quotes**. You may not change the meaning of a statement. You have **45 minutes**. Do not write your name or the name of your school on this sheet or your entry. **Put your number on your paper.**

Leaguetown High School has 800 students enrolled in grades 9-12. In November, National Honor Society president Nick Stuess, a senior, pitched a community service project to NHS members. He suggested the organization team with local businesses to provide weekend food backpacks for students who live in poverty in the school district. Stuess said they would need to make about 40 backpacks each week. The NHS voted to take on the project.

Over the past two months, NHS officers have made partnerships with the local grocery store and two business leaders to provide the food each week. The superintendent and school board members donated the 40 backpacks.

This week, the club will meet to fill the backpacks for the first time, and each backpack will get two cans of chicken, noodles, spaghetti sauce, a four-pack of pudding, four cans of soup, a bag of apples, four cans of vegetables, a box of cereal, a loaf of bread and a jar of peanut butter. The food will vary each week depending on donations.

On Fridays, counselors from the elementary, middle and high school will distribute the backpacks to the students at the end of the day. On the following Monday, the students will return the bags so the NHS can refill them for the next weekend.

The NHS will meet in the library at 6 p.m. Thursday, Feb. 7, to assemble the backpacks. You are writing for the issue of the Press to be distributed Wednesday, Feb. 6

■ NICK STUESS, NHS president

"I got the idea for this project from my cousin's church. His church partners with the local school district, and together they provide more than 1,000 food backpacks each weekend. I thought it was a cool idea and something we could definitely do here — on a much smaller basis.

"Our members embraced the project, and our goal was to have backpacks ready for students before spring break. We are definitely blowing that goal away. People's grocery store is donating some of the food, and then two local business people, who want to remain anonymous, are donating money to cover the rest of the food.

"The three pillars of the National Honor Society are service, character and leadership. This project demonstrates those qualities quite well. I was a little worried that we wouldn't have enough interest, but every member has signed up to be there Thursday."

■ **NYSSA MUÑOZ, high school counselor**

“Poverty is hidden in Leaguettown, but we definitely have it. Last month, two of our students were temporarily homeless when their parents lost their jobs. I know we have children who go hungry each week because they don’t have enough food at their home, but that is not something we broadcast to all students. I am so proud of the NHS for taking on this initiative. It’s huge, and it’s not a one-time commitment. It’s an every-week commitment that will make a difference in our town.

“I have contacted all of the high school students who will receive backpacks, and I wish I could have taken pictures of their faces when I told them. They were all so grateful.”

■ **BOB QUARLES, school board member**

“When school board members heard about this project, we wanted to pitch in, too. I couldn’t be more proud of our NHS members. This is a project our community should have taken on years ago. You can bet that I will be at the library on Thursday evening giving those students a hand. Our board wants to ensure that this project continues for many years to come.”

■ **ANNIE SMITHE, senior**

“At least two of my little brother’s friends will get the backpacks. Their parents were laid off from work, and there aren’t many jobs in our community. I hope these backpacks make their lives a little easier. When Nick first proposed the project, I thought it was a great idea, but I wondered how we would get the food each week. That was the easy part. The grocery store owner and a few community members stepped up as soon as they were asked. That was so awesome.”

■ **ANONYMOUS, junior**

“I will get one of the backpacks each week. It’s embarrassing being poor in this town. We have so many rich kids, but honestly, no one has ever made fun of me because I was poor. The backpack thing is pretty cool. My mom can’t always afford groceries. She works two jobs, but neither pays much. She was so relieved when I told her. She said she won’t have to go to the food pantry on the weekends anymore.”

ADDITIONAL INFORMATION:

Franks Burns, the manager at People’s grocery store, will deliver the groceries each week to the school.

DO NOT DISTRIBUTE TO STUDENTS BEFORE OR DURING THE CONTEST!

INVITATIONAL A • 2019

NEWS WRITING CONTEST TIPS AND SAMPLE STORY

Contest Director: Give one copy to each judge to use during critique/judging. Also, staple one copy of the contest and one copy of the contest tips to each student's returned entry. The purpose of the tips is to provide immediate feedback to students. However, it is not meant to replace written comments from the judge.

1. Open with a future lead under the present circumstances. In this instance, the story comes out before the students get their backpacks.

Forty elementary, middle and high school students who live in poverty will receive weekend food backpacks starting Friday as part of the National Honor Society latest community service project.

2. Use direct quotes and get those quotes early in the story. After you introduce quotes, use the transition/quote formula. Be sure you attribute after the quote. An attribution should be: subject of attribution followed by the verb of attribution ("Stuess said," not "said Stuess.") Avoid stacking quotes. Avoid putting two or more quotes from different people together without placing a transition between them. Also, make sure transitions provide information to help the action of the story and the quote does not repeat information revealed in the transition.

transition

The backpacks, which NHS will assemble for this first time Thursday, will contain items such as canned goods, fruits and bread. Items will vary every week based on donations.

direct quote

"My mom can't always afford groceries," a junior, who will receive a backpack, said. "She works two jobs, but neither pays much. She was so relieved when I told her. She said she won't have to go to the food pantry on the weekends anymore."

transition

High school counselor Nyssa Muñoz said poverty is not obvious here, but it exists.

direct quote

"Last month, two of our students were temporarily homeless when their parents lost their jobs," she said. "I know we have children who go hungry each week because they don't have enough food at their home."

3. Use third person. Don't say "our students" or "Our NHS president Nick Stuess" or "Some of our students..." Also, do not editorialize. For instance, you should not say "The students are so cool..." without attributing that quote to someone or "The school should ..." These statements are personal opinions and cannot be made in a news story.

4. Note how in the earlier example of transition/quote, each quote is its own paragraph. Don't be afraid to use one and two-sentence paragraphs. Journalistic writing consists mostly of one and two-sentence paragraphs.

SAMPLE STORY

Forty elementary, middle and high school students who live in poverty will receive weekend food backpacks starting Friday as part of the National Honor Society latest community service project.

Students will return backpacks to their counselors the following Monday, so NHS members can refill them for the next weekend. NHS president Nick Stuess suggested the project after seeing a similar campaign at his cousin's church.

"His church partners with the local school district, and together they provide more than 1,000 weekend food backpacks each week," Stuess said. "I thought it was a cool idea and something we could definitely do here — on a much smaller basis."

The backpacks, which NHS will assemble for this first time Thursday, will contain items such as canned goods, fruits and bread. Items will vary every week based on donations.

"My mom can't always afford groceries," a junior, who will receive a backpack, said. "She works two jobs, but neither pays much. She was so relieved when I told her. She said she won't have to go to the food pantry on the weekends anymore."

High school counselor Nyssa Muñoz said poverty is not obvious here, but it exists.

"Last month, two of our students were temporarily homeless when their parents lost their jobs," she said. "I know we have children who go hungry each week because they don't have enough food at their home."

NHS officers partnered with People's grocery store and two local business leaders to provide the food each week. Initially, NHS had a goal to deliver the first set of backpacks by spring break.

"We are definitely blowing that goal away," Stuess said.

The superintendent and school board members donated the 40 backpacks for the project.

"This is a project our community should have taken on years ago," school board member Bob Quarles said. "You can bet that I will be at the library on Thursday evening giving those students a hand. Our board wants to ensure that this project continues for many years to come."

Muñoz said she believes this project will make a difference for students.

"I have contacted all of the high school students who will receive backpacks, and I wish I could have taken pictures of their faces when I told them," Muñoz said. "They were all so grateful."



Yippee!! You're the director of the journalism contests. To make your life a little easier...

WE HAVE ENCLOSED:

- The contests
- Judging criteria
- A statement to the judges
- A statement to the contestants
- Contest Tips. (Provides examples of how stories/heads should have been written and a sample story. Clip a copy to each entry to provide immediate feedback.)

NOW, YOU NEED TO:

- Make certain you have read the journalism section of the *UIL Journalism Handbook*. You can download it free from the UIL website at: http://www.uiltexas.org/files/academics/Journalism_Handbook_2018-19.pdf.
- Inventory the contest packet. Hopefully, there won't be any problems. If you find one, please call it to my attention. Call me at work at 512/232-4924, home at 512/740-3463 or e-mail me at jacton@uiltexas.org.
- **READ THE ENCLOSED STATEMENT TO YOUR JUDGES.**
Discuss the judging criteria and clarifications with the judges.
- **Do not give the tips to students.**
- Share the "Tips" with the judges (**BEFORE** they judge) and clip one copy to each contestant's entry **AFTER JUDGING**. Judges should write directly on EVERY student's entry and then attach one copy of the Contest Tips to each entry.
- Thanks and good luck!

Statement to Judges

JOURNALISM CONTEST DIRECTOR

Please copy and distribute the following statement to the judges

1. Divide papers among the judges.
2. Every paper **MUST** be read and edited by at least one judge. *No paper should EVER be returned without written comments.*
3. Every judge does not have to read every paper. Strive for two readings for each paper. A third reading may be necessary for papers that contend for placing in the top six.
4. Avoid sarcasm or unduly harsh criticism. Remember: these are high school students, not professionals.
5. Please review the “Tips” for each contest. This sheet is consistent with the contest manual and what has been taught at conferences.
6. Realize that the UIL style may differ slightly from what you have been taught, what you practice or your newspaper’s style. If you have serious disagreement, please take them up with the UIL office, not the contestants or the meet director. For example, in the news, feature and editorial writing contests, it is not necessary to identify the school, Leaguetown High School. We create this contest as if students attend Leaguetown High School. Therefore, we assume high school students know the name of their school. Also, since AP style constantly changes, watch simply for writers to follow a consistent style. Some students (and newspapers) prefer addressing people with Mr./Mrs./Ms. title on second and subsequent uses.
7. In the Feature Writing contest, students have the freedom to develop scenes as they feel the scenes *may* have existed. The scenes must be a natural extension of the story. Please read “Contest tips” before judging.
8. In the editorial writing contest, students have the freedom to propose solutions or suggest answers they feel might resolve the problem. They do not have to be those proposed on the fact sheet. Also, they are urged to write in third person, but they may use first person plural on occasion.
9. In the headline writing contest: the main deck of a main/secondary headline combination may contain but does not need a verb. For example:

Out of Air

Statement to the Contestants

JOURNALISM CONTEST DIRECTOR

Please read the following statement to contestants

1. Place your number in the upper right hand corner of each page of your entry. Do not put your name or your school's name on any part of the contest entry. If you do, you may be disqualified.
2. Write on one side of the paper only. Write legibly. This is a request, not a requirement.
3. It is suggested that you double space so judges may edit and write comments more extensively on your entry. This is a request, not a requirement.
4. You may use a dictionary and/or a thesaurus (bound or electronic) during News, Editorial, Feature and Headline contest. You may also use an AP stylebook. You may not use a journalism text or other textbook. No resources are allowed during the Copy Editing contest.
5. You may not talk during the contest. If you have a question, raise your hand and the contest monitor will come to you.
6. If you use a computer, you are responsible should it malfunction. You will have the remaining time to complete the contest in longhand, but you will not be given extra time. You must complete the print command before the monitor asks everyone to quit writing. If the computer malfunctions do not make noise trying to fix it. The monitor will ask you to leave if you are causing too much commotion. You may not use a computer in the Headline Writing contest or the Copy Editing contest.
7. Make sure all of your electronic devices (cell phones, ipods, etc.) are turned off. You may be disqualified for disrupting the contest if your devices go off.
8. When you are finished, please turn in your paper and quietly exit.

Good luck.



JUDGING CRITERIA

SPRING MEET JOURNALISM CONTESTS

In an effort to standardize judging procedures statewide, the League office has compiled a list of journalism contest judging guidelines. This list of guidelines will be included in each district and regional contest packet and will be available to State Meet contest judges. It is the responsibility of each journalism contest director to see that all contest judges are familiar with and adhere to these guidelines.

■ HEADLINE WRITING (30 minutes) NEW TIME FOR 2019!

1. Within count. **Note:** All letters, digits, punctuation marks, spaces, grammatical marks count as one (1).
2. Wording specific, accurate; unnecessary wording omitted.
3. Verb needed in main, secondary or both decks. At times, though, a verb is not necessary in both the main and secondary head.
4. Emphasis on active verbs.
5. Past tense avoided.
6. Split phrases (modifiers, verbs) avoided.
7. Redundancy in wording avoided.
8. Does not sacrifice accuracy for creativity or cuteness.
9. Main headlines not dependent on secondary headlines.
10. Secondary headlines emphasize significant aspect of news.
11. Grammar, spelling, punctuation correct.
 - A. It is permissible to use upstyle (ALL CAPS) or downstyle headlines.
 - B. Students need not complete all six headlines to win. It is possible that five good headlines will win over six mediocre ones, or four excellent heads will win over six poor headlines. The final decision rests with the judges, but no contestants shall be disqualified solely on the basis of not completing all six headlines.

■ EDITORIAL WRITING (45 minutes)

1. Introduction presents problem, provides staff stance.
2. Lead grabs reader's attention.
3. Evidence provided to support stance taken.
4. Direct quotes avoided unless absolutely necessary.
5. Writing tight. Wording active, precise.
6. Other viewpoints presented and evidence is shown to refute those viewpoints.
7. Conclusion recaps staff position and contains call to action and/or solution.
8. Third person emphasized, although first person plural may be used occasionally.
9. Editorial tone fair, mature.
10. Secondary consideration given to:
 - A. Grammar
 - B. Spelling
 - C. Neatness

■ FEATURE WRITING (60 minutes)

1. Lead grabs reader's attention and fits mood of story. It is permissible for students to set a scene for the feature prompt. The scene may include details that are not in the prompt.
2. Writing tight. Wording active, precise.
3. Slang, clichés, jargon avoided.
4. Facts presented in logical sequence.
5. Smooth transitions.
6. Quotes, paraphrasing used effectively.
7. Persons identified fully, accurately.
8. Feature theme fully developed.
9. Utilizes time peg (if necessary)
10. Secondary consideration given to:
 - A. Grammar
 - B. Spelling
 - C. Neatness

■ NEWS WRITING (45 minutes)

1. Sound news judgment in lead selection.
2. Facts presented in descending order of importance.
3. Information flows. Smooth transitions.
4. People identified fully, accurately.
5. Quotes, paraphrasing used effectively.
6. Extraneous information omitted; writing tight.
7. Wording active.
8. All news questions answered. Newspaper style incorporated.
9. Editorialization avoided.
10. Secondary consideration given to:
 - A. Grammar
 - B. Spelling
 - C. Neatness

■ STYLE/TITLES

- ✓ Newspaper style includes the option of using titles of Mr./Mrs./Miss/Ms. with names of adults. Students should be identified fully at first mention and by last name thereafter (1st use - senior Jeanne Acton; second and subsequent uses - Acton or Ms. Acton). It is permissible to use first names only on the second reference in feature stories. AP style calls for adults to be identified by full name at first mention, and then with appropriate title and last name thereafter. Be aware of deviations from AP style. If a contestant is consistent in the use of their style, it is not recommended you penalize the contestant for not following strict AP style. We ask that you look for consistency and understandability in the use of a contestant's style.

■ SECONDARY CONSIDERATIONS

- ✓ Journalistic proficiency shall be the standard by which entries are judged. In papers of similar journalistic quality, secondary considerations of grammar, spelling and neatness may be used to determine contest results. The contest does not intend, however, to test grammar or spelling skills, and each entry should be judged on its journalistic merit before other considerations come into play.

■ COPY EDITING (15 minutes) NEW CONTEST FOR 2019

- ✓ A key to the Copy Editing Contest will be included with your material. Part III is graded only to break ties.